

IF RAHUL DISPLAYED AGGRESSION ON THE CAMPAIGN FIELD, HE SHOWED GRACE IN VICTORY. THIS WAS HIS ELECTION TO WIN OR LOSE. AND WIN HE CERTAINLY HAS, IN MORE WAYS THAN ONE.

young leader practises. Always quick to count its blessings, the Congress is now daring to dream of winning back the state in the 2012 Assembly elections.

As the party's star campaigner, Rahul covered 22 states and 107 constituencies trying to woo back the faithful. He cautioned Congressmen against falling into the BJP's India Shining trap that only reached out to the rich. Even when he spoke of the nuclear deal, he talked of its benefits to the Kalavatis rather than the Ambanis and the Mittals. Together, the troika of Sonia-Rahul-Manmohan has won a mandate for the Congress that the party has not seen for nearly two decades in Uttar Pradesh. This leadership model clearly works with Sonia and Manmohan playing mentor to the young protagonist. Only, it seems that their rather stubborn protégé has a mind of his own—a mindset that is here to stay so that older Congressmen like Veerappa Moily need to quickly master this new phenomenon.

If the youthful Rahul displayed aggression on the campaign field, he also showed grace in victory, praising L.K. Advani for "fighting a strong campaign with grit". Praise for one's adversary and that too at a time when the ecstatic leader should be savouring his own victory shows a rare and mature brand of leadership. He also refused solo credit, claiming that "if anything has to be achieved, it is by teamwork, not alone". This was Rahul's election to win or lose. And win, he certainly has. In more ways than one.

by Priya Sahgal

L.K. ADVANI

His Last Fight

It's not easy looking at the near extinction of something that is one's own creation. Shocked by the results of the Lok Sabha elections, senior BJP leaders started congregating at L.K. Advani's residence from Saturday morning. Disappointed, Advani took the people's verdict with his characteristic equanimity, at least on the surface. Senior leaders including party president Rajnath Singh, Venkaiah Naidu, campaign in-charge Arun Jaitley, Ravi Shankar Prasad and S.S. Ahluwalia were unable to comprehend what went wrong.

More than anyone else, Advani knew this was his last fight, which he hoped would culminate a five-decade political career in the Prime Minister's Office. He has taken the party's poor showing as a verdict against himself. After all, he was being projected as the NDA's candidate for the top job over the past one year. A major part of the campaign was built around Advani, projecting him



ADVANI IS NOW EXPECTED TO PLAY THE ROLE OF A PARTY PATRIARCH